Good Tidings of Great Joy

At Christmas God came to us in humility, a Saviour born for ordinary people, bringing glory to God and peace to all who receive him.

Main passage	Luke 2:1-20 (KJV)
Topic	Incarnation
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: God came in humility	7 min
Teaching point 2: Good tidings for ordinary people	7 min
Teaching point 3: Glory to God, and peace on earth	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "What is your favourite Christmas memory?" Let several people share. Then ask: "If you were planning the arrival of the King of the universe, how would you arrange it?" Contrast our ideas (palaces, press, crowds) with what God actually did.

Scripture (3 min)

Luke 2:1-20

[1] And it came to pass in those days, that there went out a decree from Cæsar Augustus, that all the world should be taxed. [2] (And this taxing was first made when Cyrenius was governor of Syria.) [3] And all went to be taxed, every one into his own city. [4] And Joseph also went up from Galilee, out of the city of Nazareth, into Judæa, unto the city of David, which is called Bethlehem; (because he was of the house and lineage of David:) [5] To be taxed with Mary his espoused wife, being great with child. [6] And so it was, that, while they were there, the days were accomplished that she should be delivered. [7] And she brought forth her firstborn

son, and wrapped him in swaddling clothes, and laid him in a manger; because there was no room for them in the inn. [8] And there were in the same country shepherds abiding in the field, keeping watch over their flock by night. [9] And, lo, the angel of the Lord came upon them, and the glory of the Lord shone round about them: and they were sore afraid. [10] And the angel said unto them, Fear not: for, behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy, which shall be to all people. [11] For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Saviour, which is Christ the Lord. [12] And this shall be a sign unto you; Ye shall find the babe wrapped in swaddling clothes, lying in a manger. [13] And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising God, and saying, [14] Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace, good will toward men. [15] And it came to pass, as the angels were gone away from them into heaven, the shepherds said one to another, Let us now go even unto Bethlehem, and see this thing which is come to pass, which the Lord hath made known unto us. [16] And they came with haste, and found Mary, and Joseph, and the babe lying in a manger. [17] And when they had seen it, they made known abroad the saying which was told them concerning this child. [18] And all they that heard it wondered at those things which were told them by the shepherds. [19] But Mary kept all these things, and pondered them in her heart. [20] And the shepherds returned, glorifying and praising God for all the things that they had heard and seen, as it was told unto them.

Read the passage aloud. This is a good passage for several readers, or for the class to read together.

Background (5 min)

Luke, a careful historian (1:1-4), anchors the birth of Jesus in real history: the reign of Caesar Augustus and a census that brought Joseph and Mary from Nazareth to Bethlehem, the town of David. Centuries earlier the prophet Micah had foretold that the ruler of Israel would come from Bethlehem (Micah 5:2).

The "manger" was a feeding trough for animals. Shepherds were ordinary working men, often looked down upon and unable to keep many religious rules because of their work. Yet they were the first to hear the news.

Teacher note: Barnes discusses a historical question about the census under Cyrenius (Quirinius) in verse 2. If someone asks, the honest answer is that scholars have proposed several solutions; Luke is otherwise a careful and reliable historian.

Teaching point 1: God came in humility (7 min)

The Son of God was born in a borrowed place and laid in a feeding trough, because "there was no room for them in the inn." The sign given to the shepherds was not a crown but a baby wrapped in cloths, lying in a manger. God came low, so that no one would be too low to come to him.

Supporting verses

Luke 2:1-7 (read from the Bible)

Philippians 2:6-8: Who, being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God: But made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant, and was made in the likeness of men: And being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself, and became obedient unto death, even the death of the cross.

2 Corinthians 8:9: For ye know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that, though he was rich, yet for your sakes he became poor, that ye through his poverty might be rich.

> *"The sign was to consist, it seems, solely in the overpowering contrast between the things just said of Him and the lowly condition in which they would find Him"*
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 2:12

> *"It is by humility that Christ comes to reign"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 2:12

Handout blanks (answers)

She laid him in a **manger**, because there was no room for them in the inn.

God came **low** so that no one would be too low to come to him.

Teaching point 2: Good tidings for ordinary people (7 min)

The first announcement went to shepherds on a night shift. "Fear not: for, behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy, which shall be to all people. For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Saviour, which is Christ the Lord" (vv. 10-11). Three titles: Saviour, Christ (the promised Messiah) and Lord. The good news is for everyone, starting with ordinary people at work.

Supporting verses

Luke 2:8-12 (read from the Bible)

Isaiah 9:6: For unto us a child is born, unto us a son is given: and the government shall be upon his shoulder: and his name shall be called Wonderful, Counsellor, The mighty God, The everlasting Father, The Prince of Peace.

Matthew 1:21: And she shall bring forth a son, and thou shalt call his name JESUS: for he shall save his people from their sins.

> *"I am not come to declare the judgments of the Lord, but his merciful loving-kindness, the subject being a matter of great joy."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 2:10

> *"We are not out of the way of divine visits when we are sensibly employed in an honest calling, and abide with God in it."*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Luke 2:8-20

Handout blanks (answers)

I bring you good tidings of great **joy**, which shall be to all people.

Unto you is born this day a **Saviour**, which is Christ the Lord.

Teaching point 3: Glory to God, and peace on earth (7 min)

The angels praised: "Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace, good will toward men" (v. 14). The shepherds went with haste, found the baby, and then told everyone. They returned "glorifying and praising God." Mary "kept all these things, and pondered them in her heart." Christmas calls for both responses: to tell, and to treasure.

Supporting verses

Luke 2:13-20 (read from the Bible)

John 1:14: And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth.

Romans 5:1: Therefore being justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ:

> *"The design of God, in the incarnation, was to manifest the hidden glories of his nature, and to reconcile men to each other and to himself."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 2:14

> *"The truths of Christ are worth keeping"*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Luke 2:8-20

Handout blanks (answers)

Glory to God in the highest, and on earth **peace**.

Mary kept all these things, and **pondered** them in her heart.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think God chose such humble circumstances for the birth of his Son?

To identify with the poor and lowly, to show that his kingdom is not like earthly kingdoms, and to make him approachable by all.

2. Why might God have announced the birth first to shepherds?

The good news is for ordinary, overlooked people; God honours the humble.

3. What do the three titles Saviour, Christ and Lord each tell us about Jesus?

Saviour: he rescues us from sin. Christ: he is the promised Messiah. Lord: he is God and King.

4. The shepherds told others; Mary pondered. Which comes more naturally to you this Christmas, and how could you practise the other?

Answers will vary.

Application (3 min)

This Christmas season, set aside time each day to "ponder" one part of the Christmas story, as Mary did. Then, like the shepherds, share the good news with one person: invite them to a Christmas service, or tell them what Jesus' coming means to you.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Glory to God in the highest! Lord Jesus, you came to us in humility, born in a manger, announced to shepherds. Thank you for coming as our Saviour, the Christ, the Lord. Give us joy like the shepherds' and wonder like Mary's. Let your peace and good will fill our hearts and homes this season. Amen.

Sources quoted

David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 2:12

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 2:12

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 2:10

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Luke 2:8-20

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 2:14

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